Writing the Routledge Guide to Canadian Literature and Digital Humanities

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From mid-2023 until late 2024 my coauthor, Sarah Roger, and I wrote *The Routledge Introduction to English-Canadian Literature and Digital Humanities*. This was a commissioned manuscript designed to introduce digital humanities methods, histories, and practical approaches to novice scholars working in the field of Canadian literature. The book is scheduled to be released in mid-2025. We wrote this book over the course of approximately one year, including a brief history of DH in Canada, methods for collecting, curating, and working with data, an introduction to programming and other DH methods of analysis, and discussions of the relationship between DH and Black Canadian studies, queer studies, and Indigenous studies.

In this paper I will discuss the experience of writing this book and present insights and challenges that arose from our work. As part of our research, we interviewed a number of prominent DH scholars in Canada and read a large collection of archival material, a great deal of which was heretofore excluded from the narrative of DH in Canada. We used this experience as the basis for writing a brief history of the emergence of DH in Canada, describing both the projects that became prominent in that history, and other projects that have been largely forgotten. I will discuss our experience interviewing subjects and collecting and working through archival material in order to put together both an oral and institutional history of DH in Canada.

Furthermore, I will discuss the challenges of writing a guide for a relatively novice audience. The experience of representing the diversity of DH methods, concerns, and objects of study was difficult and required that we try to balance our efforts to present complete picture of the DH landscape with the need to speak to an audience of beginners. This was particularly challenging when we described data curation and programming as we needed to start from first principles of file formats, interfaces, variables and control structures and then move to APIs and more complex topics. We were also aware that our attempt to present the state of DH at any given moment was bound to be out of date as soon as we submitted the manuscript.

This presentation will be a short, pithy discussion of the challenge of writing a book in a field that has not always attended to its own history, and where the focus is not typically on producing manuscripts, but where manuscripts are often the scholarly artefacts that survive and that serve as a record of the state of the field. Indeed, our history revealed how little of the ephemera associated with early digital projects has survived; it is the more traditional forms of scholarly production, manuscripts, articles, and conference proceedings, that are still available today. I will thus argue that sustaining DH requires renewed attention to the forms of scholarship that projects will leave behind as part of the record of our contribution to our field.